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BUSINESS

THE TECH TRAIL

Can't find a Miami tech job? Here's what got two candidates hired at local firms

Kimberly Tupy is a Miami tech success story. An Iowa native and a former director of student life at Miami Dade College, Tupy had long known she wanted to get into tech, having been inspired in part by the success of other women who had persevered in the field.

She did her research, and found local coding bootcamp Wyncode — now BrainStation Miami — came closest to what she was looking for in a program that could reset her career, especially its promise of lifetime career support. She attended Wyncode's user experience (UX) design course, graduating amid the pandemic.

Tupy is about to start a job as a product designer at Restaurant Brands International, the multi-billion dollar, Miami-based parent company of Burger King and Popeye's.

But that big job did not come right away. Her path illustrates that finding a job in Miami tech is quite possible — you just have to know where — and how — to look.

In fact, Tupy has already held two other jobs even in the short time since she graduated: One at a small tech company in Boca,

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and one as a product designer at Miami-based food technology company.

The key to landing the RIB job — which she said pays double her previous one — was networking locally.

"I was applying to 10-15 companies per week, each with a personalized cover letter,"

she said. But networking through Miami's design community, she said, is what allowed her to land the role she wanted.

More specifically, the breakthrough came after she joined a local UX group on Slack, one of a slew of new messaging apps that serve as virtual meet-ups.

"That was the key to my success."

The group, called FL UX, Yeah!, is technically invite only — but it already has over 1,200 members.

It is groups like these arguably constitute the heart of the Miami tech community —

perhaps as much as any that get heavily promoted on social media.

"You get to meet key people in the community at some of the major corporations in Miami, and get candid conversations with these folks,"

Tupy said. There's an unofficial mentorship program there, she said, as well as an in-person monthly meet up.

"Just like in any field, the connections you make are essential, so from my own personal experience, and of my friends from the design community, we haven't had a problem being hired at all,"

Tupy said.

Christopher Palacios is another Miami coding bootcamp grad who was able to find a job in local tech — in his case at Watco Ventures, the innovation arm of the long-time local HVAC giant.

A former electrician, Palacios found himself, at 32, looking to make a career switch. Like Tupy, Palacios chose Wyncode — though he said that of the 40-50 people who started off in his cohort, he graduated with about 20.

"That's not necessarily because people couldn't do it," he said, though some found the course moved at a

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Kimberly Tupy



Christopher Palacios



Members of the Miami-based UX+Fajitas groups, one of numerous informal networking groups that round out the Miami tech scene.

UX + Fajitas/Monica Perna

Another sign that Miami is booming? The city's getting a different kind of 'club'

BY ROB WILE
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A tradition began by East Coast business leaders more than a century ago has finally made its way to Miami.

A group of local professionals led by Jeb Bush Jr. and Miami City Attorney Jeremy Schwartz have launched the Economic Club of Miami.

According to its website, the club's goal is "to convene 21st century leaders and host events that encourage networking and thought leadership in all industries

represented in Miami." Why now? It's simple: Miami is going through an economic boom.

"It was the same when they started the Economic Club of New York," said Miami Club Executive Director Lourdes Castillo. "They needed a think tank-type meeting place for people impacted by the economy."

Once New York's club was founded, others in Chicago, Washington, D.C., Detroit and elsewhere followed.

"These booming cities got their own economic clubs — but Miami has never been in that arena," Castillo said.

"It's always been a tourist destination, always been about 'fun' — and now, because of all these businesses coming, and the branchings within the economic structure of the city, a group of us have decided to set up an Economic Club."

One-year memberships start at \$400. The group has already co-sponsored its first event, a fireside chat with Peter Thiel. Its next event, which will coincide with Art Basel, will be on NFTs and will feature FTX exchange co-founder Sam Bankman-Fried.

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Miami Club Executive Director Lourdes Castillo says Miami has "always been a tourist destination, always about fun."

CARL JOSTE: Miami Herald file, 2017